This soup contains annatto. If you've never used the spice before, it has a sweet peppery flavor and an orangey red color. It is widely used in Latin America.

cuban black bean soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS, PLUS OVERNIGHT SOAKING **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
COOK 1¾ HRS

8oz (225g) dried black beans, soaked in cold water overnight
1 bay leaf
2 cups chicken stock or ham stock
1 tbsp sunflower oil
1 large onion, finely chopped
1 garlic clove, crushed
½ tsp ground cumin
½ tsp ground annatto
pinch of ground cloves
1 beefsteak tomato, peeled and chopped
1 tsp white wine vinegar
4oz (115g) cooked ham, diced
1½ tsp brown sugar
salt and freshly ground black pepper
a few torn cilantro leaves, to garnish
corn tortilla chips, crushed, to serve
grated Cheddar, to serve

1 Drain the soaked beans and put in a large saucepan with enough water to cover by 2in (5cm). Add the bay leaf, bring to a boil, then boil rapidly for 10 minutes. Reduce the heat, cover loosely with a lid, and simmer gently for 1 hour or until really tender. Drain, reserving the liquid. Add enough stock to the cooking liquid to make 1 quart (1 liter) in all.

2 Discard the bay leaf and coarsely purée the beans and some of the stock in a blender—the mixture should not be completely smooth. Alternatively, crush with a potato masher, then set aside.

3 Heat the oil in the rinsed-out pan, add the onion, and cook gently, stirring, for 3–4 minutes or until softened but not browned. Add the garlic and cook for 1 minute, then add the spices and cook for 30 seconds. Add the tomato and vinegar and cook, stirring, for 3–5 minutes or until pulpy.

4 Add the beans, the remaining stock, and the ham. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat, and simmer gently for 20 minutes or until thickened. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper, then ladle into bowls, garnish with the cilantro, and sprinkle with tortilla chips and cheese.